examples from our research on the national and peasant movements in Punjab. When a big leader such as Jawaharlal Nehru was to come for a mass public meeting, political activists would visit villages a fortnight or more in advance to invite peasants to attend and would also ask for contributions of, say, one ser of grain, for the langar that would be organized at the meeting venue. Shopkeepers in towns would be asked to contribute small amounts of cash. With these contributions, they would run the langar, and save some to run the Congress office for some time. People gave willingly because they wanted to contribute to and invest in the movement, as it gave them a sense of ownership and a sense of dignity. Gandhi ji understood this and tried to give dignity to the poor by encouraging their active participation in struggles, and by concepts such as Daridranarayan—that God resides in the poor. The BJP has understood this and got people to contribute bricks for the Ram Mandir and iron for Sardar Patel's statue. We discussed how we also needed to evolve programmes that required the active participation and contribution of the people, especially the poor and disadvantaged sections.

Rahul Gandhi then had to leave, but he was generous enough to say that he would like to continue the conversation in Delhi.

Our visit to the Yatra concluded with the media team asking us to record our observations about the BJY in a video interview, which we did. Among other things, we pointed out that one thing that the people appreciated about the Yatra was that someone was willing to listen to them. This was because the political class had, by and large, stopped listening to them. It only talked down to them, it only broadcast its '*mann ki baat*', but didn't ever ask the people, especially the poor, to share their '*mann*' or '*dil ki baat*'. People also appreciated Rahul Gandhi's saying that he drew strength from them. Again, it gave them a sense of dignity and empowered them. We also said we were very happy to be part of the BJY, to be part of something historic, of which people were a part. We always regretted not being born in the era of the freedom struggle, and the BJY gave us an opportunity to experience something of a similar nature.